

a better camera sensor will do just fine. A laptop is only appropriate if portability is an important factor otherwise it's smarter to invest in a desktop PC – a basic rig or a mini-PC. There are a few other gadgets which are plain luxury items being promoted as one of your daily drivers. Fitness bands do an incredible job of tracking your activity but the accurate ones are expensive. For the cheap ones available in the market, they are disappointing and an utter waste of money. At a beginner's level, you can use the sensors on your smartphone that are accurate enough to track your footsteps, calories burnt and distance travelled. Another such gadget is the smartwatch. You will come across people flashing them on their wrists but broadly, they are simply a substitute for your analog or digital watch acting as a secondary screen for your



Don't spend your money on smartwatches

smartphone notifications. While some of them do include health and activity tracking features, they are still expensive and don't pose much of a utility.

If you've already bought a pair of IEMs, buying a pair of headphones whether for music or gaming wouldn't be economical. Again, they are a form of luxury that gives you better audio quality and a different level of comfort. While building a PC, you're obviously going to get yourself a speaker system. Buying Bluetooth speakers at this point again becomes a luxury but if you're one of those who love to go out on trips frequently, the JBL Go priced at under ₹2k should be enough for music. Wireless routers have become an important product at our homes and the ones installed by the ISPs aren't efficient in



Not the best but favourable for short trips

handling multiple connections. Your choice has to be TP-Link's Archer C20 priced at around ₹2k that comes with two antennas (2.4GHz and 5GHz), something rarely seen on routers at such a low price. The inclusion of a USB port at the back will let you share files in the network which is quite a useful feature.

SOFTWARE

Now that we've got gadgets out of our way, let's shift our focus towards software. Unlike gadgets, you can acquire and use software services for free. And you should be glad that almost every commercial software out there has a good enough free alternative available. You might be interested in working with documents but aren't quite keen on spending your hard earned money on the Microsoft Office suite. Among the many alternatives for word processors in the wild, apart from a few premium features, similar software such as LibreOffice, WPS, OpenOffice etc., are sufficient for an individual. Similarly, there are options available on other categories of software as well. Few of the most essential and popular ones have been covered here in an attempt to help you avoid spending unnecessary money on software.



Good alternatives for free office suites exist

Office applications

When talking about office tools and applications, you'll naturally be inclined to talk about Microsoft Office. It's a

premium set of applications covering all your needs for documentation, spreadsheets, presentations, email etc. Available at different pricing plans, the Office 365 Home gives you online cloud storage as well for a monthly fee of ₹420 per month. If you aren't comfortable in paying the amount and can manage cloud storage through other free services (more on that later), you should look at the alternatives and there are plenty to experiment. OpenOffice and LibreOffice are almost the same in terms of features since they are based on the same open-source suite. The difference between them comes only on the front-end design of LibreOffice which looks appealing and that's about it. If you're looking for a lighter solution for an office suite, WPS Office is another worthy option.

Adobe Creative Suite

Being a professional doesn't mandate that you have to buy premium software solutions due to the existence of their alternative free and open source versions. The Adobe Creative Suite is hands down the most popular creative suite in the market. And we are glad that alterna-



Only makes sense for professionals

tives exist, robust ones. Starting off with Adobe's most popular and favourite tool of the internet – Photoshop. GIMP is available on every platform and has the dedicated backing of its users trying to keep the software away from glitches. Illustrator is a powerful vector graphics editor tools and although no alternative matches the features offered, Inkscape is the most favourable option. Premiere Pro is another strong video editing tool and for this category we have two alternatives – Lightworks and DaVinci Resolve Lite. Among the two, Lightworks offers professional grade features like advanced multi-cam editing, secondary monitor